Both US and Chinese forces faced constraints due to distance in the theater of operations. US naval forces in the region were inadequate to prosecute combat operations without help, but the amount of steaming time from (a) Japan to the Spratlys, (b) Hawaii to Japan, and (c) San Diego to Japan meant that US forces were stretched too thin to fight effectively in the South China Sea. Moreover, US land-based and naval air forces could not operate at enough range to maintain persistent presence over the battle sites in the South China Sea. They were dominant in all air-to-air encounters when they were located within stand-off missile range, such as at the Battle of the Batanes and Santiago Island, but were vulnerable to SAMs fired from PLAN destroyers. The subsequent disabling of the *Gerald Ford* and the threat to aerial tankers, however, forced US forces to limit air cover after the initial days of battle.

On the other hand, the Chinese naval forces benefited from proximity to bases on the mainland and Hainan, as well as in the Paracel and Spratly Islands. Yet Chinese air forces were bested by their US opponents, and China also lost effective air cover after the early days of the war. Chinese military officials did not hesitate to use land-based missiles, especially DF-21D ASBMs against large US targets, and effectively used swarm missile attacks from smaller Type 22 missile patrol boats in both the Taiwan Strait and off Santiago Island.

Given the relatively brief duration of the war and its limitation to force-on-force battles in the littorals, neither side faced severe logistical constraints, such as lack of ordnance or fuel. American land-based and naval air forces did face a drawdown of ordnance, due to the relatively limited carrying capacity of F-35s in stealth mode. Along with routine mechanical problems, this would have wound up further limiting the effectiveness of US air operations had the conflict continued for several more weeks.

Fifth, crucially, neither Washington nor Beijing was willing to risk or felt prepared for a full war. Rather, even after the loss of their aircraft carriers, both sides showed restraint during combat operations, as noted in the third point, above. The key moment of restraint for the US was to avoid attacks on the Chinese mainland, especially missile sites,